

If using coupons was simply a matter of saving money and the product of a person's upbringing, then one would presume that most of my siblings, also raised in poverty, would be avid couponers as well. While they are frugal and shop thrift stores, of the ten of us, I was the only one that could be described as a coupon enthusiast until one sister joined me in the hobby last year.

Was it something innate in my personality then that attracted me to couponing and refunding? As a child I had the makings of a future coupon queen, volunteering to clip coupons from the inserts my dad brought home from his Sunday morning newspaper route. In the summer of 1969, when I was just ten years old, I spotted an offer for a free Wham-O Super Ball on the back of the Cheerios box and asked my mother if I could send in the box bottoms for it. I saved enough labels to order balls for myself and each of my nine siblings. While they certainly enjoyed the toy, they felt no compulsion to order one themselves. My mother humored my forays into her cabinets seeking more offers and additional labels. Even then, something about getting shiny quarters taped to postcards and crisp dollar bills tucked inside envelopes addressed in my name gave me a certain thrill, a thrill not shared by everyone, not even my frugal mother.

What is the profile of the average coupon user? How about the extreme coupon user, those of us who are crazy about coupons? What motivates one person to become obsessed with the savings that coupons can offer? How many of us are out there? And what effect do we have on the bottom line for retail stores? Once I began researching who uses coupons and why, I began wondering about the history of couponing and refunding itself.